DRAFT Museums / Primary
Thoughts & Inspirations

PERSONAL INSPIRATION

- Salisbury Cathedral & Close Strategic Planning research
- Trainee Architects: the difference between paper and computers and building sites
- Felix (brewing); difference between "designing" a brew and seeing the physical process
- Grayson Perry.....
- History World 100 objects, Neil MacGregor..... consequential thinking

EDUCATIONALLY

- value of tangible object experience teaching MAKE
- "everyday participation" culture/children/families
- understand the past and project into the future
- arts; sciences; humanities
- citizenship; diversity; accessibility

PRIMARY SCHOOLS

- small
- flexible
- foundation for secondary
- small people highly underestimated in terms of learning capacity once stimulated or inspired (eg. bi & tri-lingual children...)

For the last seven years I have had my own architectural practice specialising in public cultural projects, with Clients most notably including Tate Modern and Salisbury Cathedral. Prior to that I have worked internationally, nationally and regionally in both public and private sector, also very often with Schools, Universities and Museums; I attach my cv and you can also see my practice link below.

So, now, after many years of architectural practice I have come to the great conclusion that my principal interests are indeed museums and education; more specifically I have been developing an idea for quite a while, and want to find a way of taking it further:

It is simply that I believe that it could be a really good idea to site (some) primary schools at, or directly attached to, museums.

My principal reason for this is that I think there would be a tremendous opportunity for children, in such a symbiotic location, to be able to absorb local collections almost by osmosis; a constant weave of reference across the

curriculum. This would be a fundamentally different experience, qualitatively, from simply visiting, however inspiring school or family trips clearly are.

But there seem to be so many other reasons for doing this. Here are just a few, to give you a flavour of my thoughts, and in no particular order.

- Cultural Continuity/Identity/Citizenship; an understanding of what it is to know "our" local/regional/national collections and where that particular school and children sit relative to it.
- a clear setting-to-rights of issues of exclusion in museums or cultural heritage
- making a museum just part of all local (catchment area) children's daily life (and their families')
- inspiring making and creativity; clearly digital information is so important today, but the physical knowledge embedded within objects has phenomenal depths across all subjects. Bring the objects to life and counter the digital head world with the tactile material world in arts, sciences and humanities. A working title might include "**MAKE**(-ing)" schools - Museums As ***Knowledgable*** Environments, viz. as opposed to (just...) places of *Information*
- the ability to look backwards, seek inspiration and project forwards along axes suggested by the collections' parameters. Where do I come from? Where am I going to? The values of the local community across time.
- Facilities:- there are many common elements in the physical fabric between museums and schools
    - cloakrooms, toilets, eating places
    - some classrooms (already!)
    - larger gathering spaces
    - security, heat, light

We understand there is currently a grave shortage of primary school places: many museums could, with some relatively simple re-ordering or extension readily provide fit for purpose accommodation, representing good capital cost value for money and onward sharing of the running costs. I have delivered quite a few primary schemes in the past and feel hat the accommodation requirements could be flexibly inspired by various museum properties. *I do however think that secondary accommodation would be too much of a push, but having been steeped in such an environment as a primary child, I think that secondary visits or partnership schools would then have a great foundation on which to continue to build.*

I personally can see such a rich field of application in city, regional or rural areas. Ideally I would like to find a museum and school partnership and trial the idea! Clearly I am a practitioner and not an academic to date, although I have always done quite a lot of teaching or mentoring of one sort or another (I will shortly lead a session on the Tate / King's College "Towards Tomorrow's Museum" course, partly through Alex ! ...)

I have looked at some other, partly related, projects

- Museum Schools in US including for instance San Diego, Avondale, NYC where there seems to be a great emphasis on partnership and a far greater number of visits.
- Museum Schools programme, Bhopal, India - a wonderful programme that simply opens museums for street kids who can treat it like school as and when they can overcome other pressures in life to attend
- in the UK there is Langley Academy, Slough which also emphasises Museum learning (separate site and secondary ...)

None of these are exactly what I am thinking of though .....